

Perceived Flexibility, Burnout, and Academic/Professional Performance: An Exploratory Study Among Students and Workers

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Abstract—This study explores the relationships between perceived flexibility, burnout, psychological stress, and academic/professional performance among French- and English-speaking students and workers. A total of 172 participants completed an online questionnaire assessing perceived flexibility, burnout, and perceived performance. The findings indicate that greater perceived flexibility is associated with lower levels of burnout and higher levels of performance. Conversely, burnout was negatively associated with performance. Significant gender differences were also observed, with women reporting higher levels of burnout than men. These findings suggest that perceived flexibility may play a protective role in psychological well-being and academic/professional functioning.

I. INTRODUCTION

Psychological stress and burnout have become major concerns in both academic and professional settings. The demands associated with studying, working, and balancing personal and professional responsibilities can negatively affect psychological well-being and individual performance. Previous research suggests that high levels of stress and mental fatigue are associated with reduced motivation, satisfaction, and academic or professional functioning.

At the same time, work and study arrangements have evolved considerably over recent years, particularly with the increasing adoption of flexible practices such as remote work, adaptable schedules, and hybrid environments. Perceived flexibility may represent a protective factor that enables individuals to better manage their responsibilities and reduce some of the negative effects associated with psychological stress. Several studies have suggested that greater flexibility is associated with improved well-being and lower levels of burnout (Costa et al., 2009).

Recent research has also indicated that flexibility in managing the boundaries between work and study can reduce burnout and promote academic engagement among working students (Creed et al., 2022). These findings support the idea that flexibility constitutes a psychological resource that facilitates adaptation to academic and professional demands.

The present study therefore aims to examine the relationships between perceived flexibility, burnout, and aca-

demic/professional performance among a sample of French- and English-speaking students and workers.

Drawing on previous literature, several main hypotheses were developed:

- **H1:** Perceived flexibility will be negatively associated with psychological stress and burnout.
- **H2:** Psychological stress and burnout will be negatively associated with academic/professional performance.
- **H3:** Perceived flexibility will be positively associated with academic/professional performance.

Despite these encouraging findings, the relationships between perceived flexibility, burnout, and performance remain complex and warrant further investigation, particularly among student and working populations who must manage multiple responsibilities simultaneously. Previous research also suggests that the effects of flexibility and psychological stress may vary across gender groups, notably due to differences in the management of personal and professional responsibilities (Kim et al., 2019).

In addition to the main hypotheses, several exploratory hypotheses were also formulated:

- **H4:** Significant gender differences are expected in psychological stress, burnout, and perceived performance.
- **H5:** Burnout levels may differ according to participants' academic/professional status.

II. METHODS

A. Participants

The final sample consisted of 172 French- and English-speaking participants aged 18 years and older. Participants were distributed across four age groups: 18–24 years ($n = 63$), 25–30 years ($n = 57$), 31–40 years ($n = 29$), and 41 years and older ($n = 23$).

The sample was evenly balanced by gender, with 86 women and 86 men.

Regarding academic/professional status, 54 participants were students, 82 were employed, and 36 simultaneously combined studying and working.

Participants voluntarily and anonymously completed an online questionnaire distributed through various digital platforms. No financial compensation was provided.

B. Materials and Measures

Data were collected using a questionnaire composed of multiple items rated on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).

Perceived flexibility was assessed using several items related to autonomy, adaptability, schedule control, flexibility of tasks and academic/professional contexts, and satisfaction with the organization of work or studies.

Burnout and psychological stress were assessed through items measuring mental exhaustion, perceived stress, and feelings of being overwhelmed by academic or professional responsibilities.

Perceived academic/professional performance was assessed using items related to motivation, productivity, concentration, goal attainment, and overall satisfaction with the quality of one's work or studies.

C. Procedure

The questionnaire was distributed online to French- and English-speaking participants who met the study eligibility criteria. Participation was voluntary, and no financial compensation was offered.

Following data collection, the dataset underwent a cleaning process prior to statistical analyses. Incomplete or invalid responses were excluded from the final sample before analyses were conducted.

D. Statistical Analyses

Statistical analyses were conducted using RStudio. Composite scores were created for the main variables by calculating the mean of their corresponding items.

The internal consistency of the scales was assessed using Cronbach's alpha. Correlation analyses were then conducted to examine the relationships among perceived flexibility, burnout, and academic/professional performance.

Analyses of variance (ANOVAs) were also performed to examine differences according to gender and academic/professional status. Finally, a multiple regression analysis was conducted to evaluate the contribution of perceived flexibility and burnout in predicting academic/professional performance.

III. RESULTS

A. Scale Reliability

The different scales used in this study demonstrated good internal consistency. The perceived flexibility scale showed a Cronbach's alpha of $\alpha = .85$, indicating good internal reliability. The burnout and psychological stress scale demonstrated excellent internal consistency ($\alpha = .93$). Finally, the perceived academic/professional performance scale also demonstrated good internal consistency ($\alpha = .83$).

These findings suggest that the items composing each scale consistently measured the psychological constructs under investigation.

B. Correlations

Correlation analyses were conducted to examine the relationships among perceived flexibility, burnout, and perceived academic/professional performance.

A moderate negative correlation was observed between perceived flexibility and burnout ($r = -.38$), indicating that greater perceived flexibility was associated with lower levels of burnout. Burnout was also negatively correlated with performance ($r = -.52$), suggesting that higher levels of burnout were associated with lower perceived performance. Finally, a moderate positive correlation was observed between perceived flexibility and performance ($r = .50$), indicating that greater perceived flexibility was associated with higher academic/professional performance.

These findings support the study's main hypotheses regarding the relationships among flexibility, burnout, and performance.

TABLE I
MEANS, STANDARD DEVIATIONS, AND CORRELATIONS AMONG THE MAIN VARIABLES

Variables	M	SD	1	2	3
1. Flexibility	3.60	.90	—		
2. Burnout	3.32	1.19	-.38***	—	
3. Performance	3.64	.71	.50***	-.52***	—

Note. * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$.

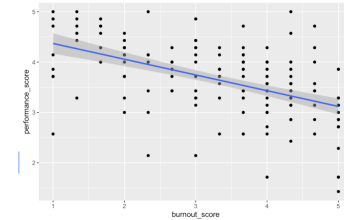


Fig. 1. Relationship Between Burnout and Academic/Professional Performance.

Note. $N = 172$.

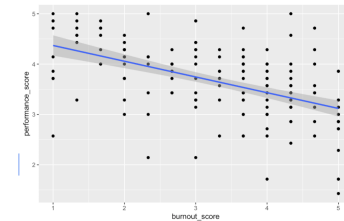


Fig. 2. Relationship Between Perceived Flexibility and Burnout.

Note. $N = 172$.

C. Multiple Regression

A multiple linear regression analysis was conducted to examine the effects of perceived flexibility and burnout on academic/professional performance.

The results indicated that perceived flexibility positively predicted performance ($\beta = .28, p < .001$), whereas burnout negatively predicted performance ($\beta = -.23, p < .001$). The overall model was statistically significant, $F(2,169) = 51.63, p < .001$, and explained approximately 38

These findings suggest that higher levels of perceived flexibility are associated with better performance, whereas higher levels of burnout are associated with lower academic/professional performance.

D. Differences According to Academic/Professional Status

An analysis of variance (ANOVA) was conducted to examine differences in burnout according to participants' academic/professional status.

The results revealed a significant difference in burnout across status groups, $F(2,169) = 7.83, p < .001$. Tukey post-hoc comparisons indicated that students reported significantly higher levels of burnout than employed participants ($p < .001$). Participants who simultaneously combined studying and working also reported higher levels of burnout than employed participants ($p < .001$).

These findings suggest that academic demands may be associated with higher levels of psychological exhaustion, particularly among students and individuals who combine studying and working.

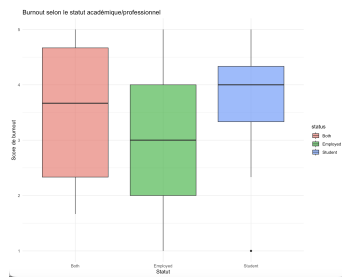


Fig. 3. Burnout Differences According to Academic/Professional Status.
Note. N = 172.

E. Gender Differences

An analysis of variance (ANOVA) was also conducted to examine gender differences in burnout and academic/professional performance.

The results revealed a significant gender difference in burnout, $F(1,170) = 19.98, p < .001$. Female participants reported significantly higher levels of burnout than male participants.

These findings support the exploratory hypothesis suggesting that gender differences may be observed with respect to burnout and perceived performance.

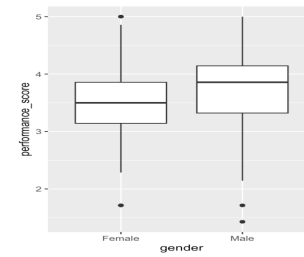


Fig. 4. Gender Differences in Perceived Performance.
Note. N = 172.

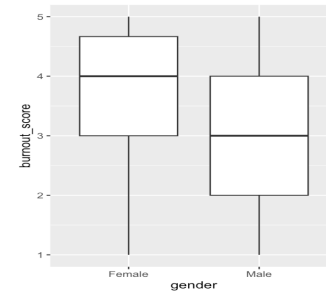


Fig. 5. Gender Differences in Burnout.
Note. N = 172.

IV. DISCUSSION

The present study aimed to examine the relationships among perceived flexibility, burnout, psychological stress, and academic/professional performance in a sample of students and workers. Overall, the findings supported the hypotheses formulated at the outset of the study.

The analyses revealed that greater perceived flexibility was associated with lower levels of burnout and higher perceived academic/professional performance. Conversely, higher levels of burnout were associated with lower levels of perceived performance.

These findings suggest that perceived flexibility may function as a psychological resource that promotes adaptation to academic and professional demands while reducing the negative effects of psychological stress and mental exhaustion.

The present findings are consistent with previous research on flexibility and psychological well-being. For example, Costa et al. (2009) found that certain forms of workplace flexibility were associated with improved well-being and psychological health. Similarly, Moen et al. (2016) reported that organizational initiatives promoting greater flexibility and workplace support contributed to reduced stress and improved employee well-being. The results of the present study therefore support the notion that perceived flexibility may serve as a protective factor against burnout and mental fatigue.

The analyses also revealed significant differences according to academic/professional status. Students reported higher levels of burnout than employed participants, while individuals who simultaneously combined studying and working also

reported elevated levels of psychological exhaustion. These findings may be explained by academic demands, performance pressure, and the challenges associated with balancing multiple responsibilities. They are also consistent with recent research suggesting that working students may be at greater risk of psychological stress and mental fatigue when managing multiple roles simultaneously.

Significant gender differences were also observed. Female participants reported higher levels of burnout and slightly lower levels of perceived performance than male participants. Although these findings should be interpreted cautiously, they may reflect differences in the management of personal, academic, and professional responsibilities. Previous research suggests that women may be more exposed to mental load and challenges associated with balancing multiple life domains (Kim et al., 2019). However, variables related to family and domestic responsibilities were not directly assessed in the present study, which limits the interpretation of these gender differences.

Several limitations should be acknowledged. First, all data were based on self-report measures, which may introduce biases related to participants' subjective perceptions. Second, the study employed a cross-sectional design, preventing any direct causal conclusions regarding the relationships among perceived flexibility, burnout, and performance. Furthermore, participants were recruited online on a voluntary basis, which may limit the generalizability of the findings to the broader student and working populations.

Despite these limitations, the present study highlights the potential importance of perceived flexibility for psychological well-being and academic/professional performance. The findings suggest that greater flexibility in the organization of work or studies may contribute to lower levels of burnout and improved psychological functioning. They also underscore the importance of further research examining factors that may reduce psychological stress among students and workers, particularly the roles of mental load, personal responsibilities, and gender-related differences.

V. CONCLUSION

This exploratory study highlighted significant relationships among perceived flexibility, burnout, and academic/professional performance in a sample of students and workers. The findings suggest that greater perceived flexibility is associated with lower levels of burnout and higher levels of perceived performance.

The analyses also revealed differences according to gender and academic/professional status, emphasizing the importance of considering the psychological and organizational realities experienced by different groups of participants.

In a context where work and study arrangements are becoming increasingly flexible, these findings underscore the potential value of practices that promote autonomy, schedule adaptability, and a better balance between different life domains. This research therefore contributes to a better understanding

of the factors that may support psychological well-being and academic/professional functioning in contemporary contexts.

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